

REAPER

Deliberate Practice Plan

Mixing & Mastering → Sound Design for Screen & Games

A structured, progressive skill-building roadmap for audio engineers transitioning into Reaper for music production and game/screen sound design.

How to Use This Plan

This plan assumes you're an experienced audio engineer — ears and instincts are already developed. The goal is not to teach audio from scratch; it's to systematically build **Reaper workflow fluency**, then layer sound design craft for screen and game contexts on top of a solid mixing foundation.

Principle	What it means in practice
Narrow focus	One skill cluster per stage. Don't jump ahead.
Real output	Every stage ends with a deliverable you can critically review.
Honest review	Log what didn't work. Your old work improves faster than you think.
Reuse real jobs	Where possible, use actual client work as training material.

Stages are roughly weekly but treat them as milestone-gated, not calendar-gated. Move on when the output checkpoint feels solid.

Skill Areas Overview

Area	What you'll build
1. Mixing & Mastering in Reaper	Translating your Ableton M&M; workflow — routing, FX chains, metering, stem export, mastering setup. Streaming-focused loudness targets (-14 LUFS / -1 dBTP).
2. Reaper DAW Fluency	Item-based editing, the action list, custom shortcuts, SWS extension, project routing. The 'thinking differently' layer that unlocks everything else.
3. Reaper for Sound Design	Media Explorer, pitch/time tools, render matrix, region/marker batch export, MIDI & instrument routing.
4. Sound Design Craft	Layering methodology, synthesis fundamentals, processing as design, foley & field recording.
5. Screen & Game Context	Spotting to picture, sync workflows, game asset conventions, variation sets, middleware awareness (Wwise/FMOD).
6. Pipeline & Integration	Batch export/rename, metadata tagging, personal library building, loudness QC for delivery.

Goal: Translate your Ableton M&M; workflow into Reaper. By the end you should be comfortable taking a real mix job entirely in Reaper.

Skills to Build

- Session & project architecture — tracks, folders, colour coding
- Routing & mix busses — sends, receives, hardware outputs
- FX chains & FX containers — grouping and recalling plugin chains
- Track templates & project templates — your blank canvas
- Metering & loudness — LUFS meter setup, -14 LUFS integrated / -1 dBTP true peak for streaming
- Stem & bounce export — render dialog, format options
- Mastering chain setup — mid/side routing, limiting, dithering in Reaper
- Ableton→Reaper translation map — what changed, what's equivalent, what's better

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- Rebuild your go-to Ableton mix template from scratch inside Reaper
- Take a finished Ableton mix session and re-open it in Reaper — document every translation gap
- Mix a full track end-to-end in Reaper; measure integrated LUFS on final export
- Build a mastering chain as an FX chain preset; apply it to 3 different genres
- Create keyboard shortcuts for your 10 most-used mix actions
- Export stems from a real session using Reaper's render matrix

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → A finished, streaming-ready master (-14 LUFS / -1 dBTP) completed entirely inside Reaper, plus your personal project template saved and documented.

■ Use real client work here where possible — deliberate practice compounds fastest when the stakes are genuine.

Goal: Stop fighting the DAW. Reaper should feel like a natural extension of thought, not a series of menu hunts.

Skills to Build

- Item-based editing — understanding the item/track/take model
- Action list — finding, assigning, and chaining actions
- Custom actions & macros — building multi-step keyboard shortcuts
- SWS extension — markers, snapshots, batch processing, region tools
- Grouping, folders, and routing graphs
- ReaScript basics (Lua) — optional but valuable for automation

Deliberate Practice

- Spend 20 min/day on editing-only exercises — no plugins, just cuts, fades, takes
- Find 10 things you do manually; assign or create custom shortcuts for all 10
- Rebuild a session you know well from Ableton purely in Reaper to expose gaps
- Install SWS; use its marker/region tools for a full session
- Write one simple ReaScript that automates a repetitive task (e.g. name all items by track name)

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → A personalised Reaper action list printout + a sound design session template with your routing, FX containers, and track structure ready to go.

■ *This stage feels slow. Push through — it pays compound interest across everything that follows.*

Goal: Understand transformation. One raw recording becomes five completely different sounds using only Reaper's native tools.

Skills to Build

- Pitch shifting & time stretching — ReaPitch, élastique modes, item properties
- Reversals, time-reversal tails, envelope shapes
- Convolution reverb as design (not just space) — ReaVerb
- Saturation, distortion, spectral shifting
- Pitch envelope automation — creating movement
- Media Explorer — auditioning and dragging in sources efficiently

Deliberate Practice

- Each session: one recorded source (door slam, metal scrape, your voice) → 5 distinct sounds
- Constraint: native Reaper tools only — no third-party plugins yet
- Log results in a 'transformation map': what process produced what feel
- Record at least 10 original sources yourself (don't rely on libraries yet)
- At end of stage: build 20–30 sound assets from only 3–4 raw recordings

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → A personal SFX mini-pack (20–30 assets) built from 3–4 raw recordings. Accompanying transformation map document.

■ *The native-tools constraint is intentional — it builds deep Reaper knowledge and forces creative problem solving before you reach for a plugin.*

Goal: Design sounds that serve a purpose, not just sound interesting. Every layer should earn its place by serving the emotional or physical result.

Skills to Build

- Layering methodology — sub, body, texture, transient, tail
- Synthesis fundamentals — subtractive, FM, granular (minimum: know what each does)
- Processing as design — ring mod, spectral tools, pitch-tracked effects
- Foley thinking — what materials map to what emotions
- Reference analysis — deconstructing professional sound design
- Mix balance within the design (your M&M; background is an asset here)

Deliberate Practice

- Pick a reference: a game or film scene with sound design you respect
- Recreate 5 sounds from memory — not by ear-matching, but by asking 'what layers produce this feeling?'
- Then listen to the original and diagnose the gap honestly
- Introduce a synth (VITAL is free) for elements you can't record
- Write a 5-sound breakdown doc: layers used, why, what you'd change

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → 5-sound design breakdown document with layer maps, plus a layered Reaper session with all stems clearly named and exported.

■ *Your mix background is a real advantage here — many sound designers struggle with how layers sit against each other. You already have that intuition.*

Goal: Apply your sound design in real delivery contexts — synced to picture for screen, variation-ready and export-clean for games.

Skills to Build

- Spotting to picture — locking Reaper to video, hit point marking, frame rates
- Ambience beds — looping, seamless transitions, layered density
- Trailer/cinematic conventions — rise, impact, tail, emotional arc
- Game asset conventions — loops vs one-shots, variation sets, naming standards
- Region render matrix — batch exporting named assets
- Wwise/FMOD awareness — understanding how assets will be used downstream
- Loudness QC for game delivery (often -18 to -23 LUFS depending on platform/middleware)

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- SCREEN: Spot a 30–90 sec scene (trailer, short film, game cinematic) — ambience, foley, FX, transitions
- SCREEN: Focus on sync, emotional arc, and mix balance relative to any existing music
- GAMES: Pick one mechanic (weapon fire, UI button, character jump, enemy hit)
- GAMES: Design a variation set — 4–6 variations so repetition doesn't feel robotic
- GAMES: Export via region render matrix with correct naming conventions
- Compare your game asset naming against a real Wwise/FMOD project structure

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → One screen scene (full SFX pass, mixed to picture) + one game mechanic set (variation-ready, correctly named, export-clean).

■ Split your practice time roughly 50/50 between screen and game work during this stage to build both pipelines in parallel.

Goal: Deliberate practice never ends — it gets more targeted. Build speed, depth, and a personal library that compounds over time.

Skills to Build

- Timed design challenges — working under creative constraints
- Personal sample library — tagging, searchability, metadata (BWF/Soundminer)
- Quarterly retrospectives — reviewing old work with fresh ears
- Specialisation depth — identify 1–2 areas (e.g. sci-fi, horror ambience) and go deep
- Pipeline QC habits — loudness, format, naming, metadata checks before delivery

Deliberate Practice

- Weekly timed challenge: design a specific sound in 30–45 minutes
- After every project, add 5–10 reusable assets to your personal library with full tags
- Every 3 months: re-listen to your Stage 2 output — document what your ear now catches
- Build a 'sound design toolkit' Reaper session with your go-to processing chains
- Contribute to or critique a peer's design work — teaching accelerates your own learning

OUTPUT CHECKPOINT → A searchable personal SFX library of 200+ tagged assets, and a documented 'design toolkit' session template.

■ *Speed comes from internalised decisions, not rushing. Each timed challenge builds faster access to the judgment you've already developed.*

Priority Cheat Sheet

If you can only focus on a few things first

Priority	Skill	Why it matters
#1	Mixing routing & FX chains in Reaper	Gets you billable immediately using Reaper for real M&M; work.
#2	Item editing & custom actions	Unlocks Reaper's true power; everything else builds on this.
#3	Region render matrix	Immediately useful for game asset delivery and stem export.
#4	Layering discipline	The single biggest lever on sound design quality.
#5	Spotting to picture	Opens screen/trailer work without needing a separate DAW.

Your post-production and mix background is a genuine advantage — you already understand how sound sits in a mix, which many sound designers struggle with. The gap to close is the *generative and transformative* side: taking raw material and sculpting it into something intentional. That's what Stages 2–5 are built around.